Haskayne
School of Business

Becoming AI-Resilient: The Twist

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Congratulations! You've diagnosed the triple threat of operational overwhelm, existential anxiety, and AI-driven disruption, and proposed a thoughtful, empathetic solution to help students discover their superpowers, understand the changing world of work, build resilience, and create continuous growth loops. Now it's time to build and bring it to life.

Ideas alone are no longer sufficient in today's digital environment. Students are not looking for another theoretical framework; they are seeking tangible, engaging, and personalized tools that meet them in those moments of doubt. Universities across Canada subsequently do not suffer from a shortage of reports or recommendations. They suffer from a shortage of actionable solutions. They are seeking ready-to-implement digital experiences that can adapt and resonate with a generation shaped by technology.

In the first case challenge, you were asked to think strategically. You identified structural gaps in the undergraduate experience and proposed a vision for institutional transformation. But now, the leaders of Ascend Career Labs are asking the pressing question,

"*What would this actually look like in practice?*"

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The Exponential Acceleration of AI and Technology

Your digital solution is being designed at a moment of unprecedented technological acceleration. Large Language Models (LLMs), AI agents, and generative systems are not evolving linearly; they are compounding at an exponential rate. Artificial intelligence adoption has entered a phase of mass acceleration. According to the Digital 2026 Global Overview Report, more than one billion people worldwide are now using AI-powered tools, a scale that would be unimaginable just five years ago. Evidently, it is reshaping knowledge work, creativity, hiring practices, and even identity formation in real time. When AI can pass bar exams, medical licensing, and engineering problem sets, the question is no longer "What do students know?" but "What can students become?"

A resilience tool designed for a stable world will fail in an exponential one. Students do not need better career planning; they need a fundamentally different relationship with uncertainty. In this environment, digital innovation in higher education is no longer optional; it is foundational.

The Challenge: Build a Digital MVP

In this second phase of the challenge, you will move from your concept proposal to a prototype. This is not a consulting exercise. This is a digital innovation race. You are no longer advising, you are building. Your task is to translate your proposed solution into a functional, demonstrable digital experience, a Minimum Viable Product (MVP), that delivers measurable value to a student navigating uncertainty.

Crucially, your MVP must be embedded within a clearly articulated student journey. This MVP must move beyond conceptual description and should be a digital, interactive experience that brings one pivotal moment of your solution to life. It should allow judges to feel what a student would encounter when they engage with your idea. Judges should feel the “before”, witness the moment of interaction, and clearly see the “after”, not in what the student knows, but in how they feel and what they are now able to do differently.

An MVP is not the full realization of your long-term vision. It is a purposeful section of your broader solution. It is the most meaningful component that demonstrates how your idea works in practice. The goal is not to build an entire platform, but to show in a tangible way how your solution works in practice, and what changes for the student as a result.

You are walking us through a student’s journey, so the student must be at the heart of your demonstration.

You may refine or narrow your original solution. While your entire solution might not be digital, the core element you present at the competition must be digital, experiential rather than descriptive, interactive rather than static, and unique at its core. It is to be understood that your entire proposed solution may not be digital, but this MVP will be the digital component you are highlighting.

What We Are Looking For: The Three Pillars

Your presentation will be evaluated on your ability to balance three core requirements.

1) **Creativity:** Your solution must be original. You are welcome to use any tools or apps that help you create your MVP, but your final product should not rely on or reuse existing platforms that already solve this problem. We want you to design a digital experience that is your own something new, imaginative and created specifically for this challenge.

2) **Feasibility:** While creativity is encouraged, your solution must be grounded in what can realistically be built using today's technology. Your MVP must be built and demonstrable in some form. The focus is not on presenting a detailed implementation or rollout plan, but on showing that the technology behind your MVP is credible, coherent, and meaningfully shapes the experience you are presenting. Judges should be able to clearly envision how what you demonstrate could exist beyond the competition. Your MVP does not need to be fully scaled, but it should feel functional, achievable, and technically plausible, not hypothetical.

3) **Application to Digital Innovation:** This competition is a Digital Innovation Challenge. Craig Lipset's view of digital innovation is your benchmark. Your solution cannot simply be a digital wrapper around an old idea. Recommendations such as "use LinkedIn more effectively" or "adopt Canva-based toolkits" will not suffice.

"***Digital innovation, like all innovation efforts, is about ideas that derive value. Ideas alone are not sufficient; the digital solution must be able to add value to a process, business, or outcome for it to earn the title of "digital innovation.***"

– Craig Lipset, Advisor and Founder at Clinical Innovation Partners.

Your innovation may lie in:

- **Personalization:** For example, using AI to adapt content to a student's values, stressors, or goals
- **Behavioral design:** Embedding resilience-building into existing digital habits
- **Social connection:** Transforming isolated reflection into shared growth
- **Visualization:** Making progress, purpose, and potential visible
- **Accessibility:** Reaching students who never visit career centres or counselling services

These three pillars are not constraints to be resolved. They are designed materials to be worked with. Your task is not to maximize creativity at the expense of feasibility, nor to prioritize feasibility while losing the digital innovation. Your task is to hold all three simultaneously and produce something that honours each.

Guiding Principle of this challenge

Think less about the tool and more about the experience:

What is the moment of transformation you want a student to have, and how can digital technology bring that moment to life?

Deliverables

Your live presentation must include:

- **The Problem (2 minutes)**: A brief resonant recap of the student crisis your solution aims to address. This should not be a full repeat of your Case 1 analysis.

- **The Student Journey**: Before presenting the solution, outline the journey of a student navigating uncertainty with your solution from start to finish. What actions can they take within your MVP, what moment initiates the engagement, and what are the results of the interaction? Highlight the before, during, and after engagement. This section should establish the emotional and practical premise of the experience.

- **Demo of the Digital Solution**:
    - An introduction to your MVP, its core features, and the main values it delivers. Remember, you don’t have to justify your solution; lead the judges to the main experience.
    - A live walkthrough through your PowerPoint slides or a recorded video simulation of the complete student experience. This is the core of your presentation. You are welcome to do more, but within the presentation

time, you cannot request that the judges download anything.

- **Feasibility & Next Steps (2 minutes):** Briefly reinforce the feasibility of your MVP and outline a few next steps that could further strengthen or extend the solution beyond the competition.

**Note: The suggested timings are intended to support pacing rather than serve as strict requirements. Teams are encouraged to dedicate the majority of their presentation time to the student journey and demonstration components, as these represent the primary focus of evaluation, while remaining generally aligned with the recommended structure.*

We look forward to experiencing how your teams bring this Case Twist to life and to seeing solutions that thoughtfully translate insight into meaningful experiences for students navigating uncertainty.